Lesson 10 material: Grammar: Phrasal Verbs

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 1: Academic Writing Essentials · Psychology

3.4: Grammar Presentation-Phrasal Verbs

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Phrasal verbs are verbs usually followed by a preposition to form one meaning. For example, the phrasal verb **put off** means to delay or postpone. Phrasal verbs can be categorized as separable or inseparable. Separable phrasal verbs can be kept together or separated by nouns or pronouns. Inseparable phrasal verbs cannot be separated by a noun or pronoun. Look at the examples.

1. I looked up the new word in the dictionary. (separable phrasal verb kept together)
2. I look the new word up in the dictionary. (separable phrasal verb separated)
3. I look up to my grandmother. (inseparable phrasal verb)

For more information on this topic, watch these videos: Phrasal Verbs (Structure)-Lesson 18-English Grammar and English Phrasal Verbs for Everyday Life

Video: https://youtu.be/hcOivE5XH3g

Video: https://youtu.be/G2NwmcNKaHk

1.3.4.1. Separable Phrasal Verbs

Separable phrasal verbs can have a noun or pronoun between the verb and preposition. However, they can only have a noun, not a pronoun, after the preposition. Look at the examples.

1. Hyun-Ki **gave** smoking **up**.
2. Hyun-Ki **gave up** smoking.
3. Hyun-Ki **gave** it **up**.
4. Hyun-Ki **gave up** it. (incorrect)

The phrasal verb is separated by a noun (example 1) and pronoun (example 3). In example 2, the phrasal verb is kept together and followed by a noun. However, in example 4, the phrasal verb is kept together and incorrectly followed by a pronoun. While it is not common, some phrasal verbs *must be* separated. The table below has a list of separable phrasal verbs. Those that must be separated are marked with an asterisk (*).

Phrasal Verb	**Meaning**	**Phrasal Verb**	**Meaning**
ask over*	invite	blow up	explode
bring back	return	bring up	bring attention to
build up	increase	break down	thoroughly explain
call back*	return a phone call	call off	cancel
carry out	implement	calm down	decrease emotions
drop off	leave someone or something at a place	figure out	understand or solve
fill in	complete	fill out	complete
fill up	fill completely	fix up	repair/make presentable
find out	learn new information	get across	get people to understand
give up	quit	give out	distribute
give back	return	hang up	end a phone call
help out	assist	leave out	exclude
let down	disappoint	pass down	give
pick up	lift/get	put away	put in the correct place
put off	postpone	take off	remove
throw away	put in the trash	turn on/off	make something open or start/ stop or finish

Table 11 Separable Phrasal Verbs

For more information on this topic, watch this video: An Introduction to Phrasal Verbs

Video: https://youtu.be/e7tZSwasnR0

1.3.4.1.1. Exercise 3-Pronoun Objects

Read the sentences that have a noun used with a phrasal verb. Rewrite the sentence using a pronoun. Use the example as a guide.

Example: Sadie always **leaves out** her youngest cousin, Alyssa. = Sadie always **leaves** her **out**.

1. Wei forgot to give back the money.
2. Joan wants to ask Jacobo over for lunch.
3. The teacher broke down the grammar rule so that students could better understand the process.
4. Please fill up my thermos with coffee. I'm tired!
5. We need to help out the team members because they are struggling to complete the project.
6. My children hate to pick up their laundry.
7. The nurse told Paolo to take off his shirt.
8. Have you called your friends back?
9. Sometimes children hang up the phone prematurely.
10. It's not efficient to have the light on during the day. Please turn off the light.

1.3.4.1.2. Exercise 4-Separable Phrasal Verbs Meaning Practice

Read the sentences and determine which phrasal verb would be the most appropriate considering its meaning.

1. My sister _____ the meeting when she came down with the flu.
a. picked up
b. carried out
c. called off
d. fixed up
2. After having the flu, she had to _____ her appetite slowly.
a. fill out
b. pass down
c. find out
d. build up
3. Sylvie _____ the house before her friends came over.
a. fixed up
b. helped out
c. threw away
d. asked over
4. Americans _____ too much plastic. They should reuse, reduce, and recycle.
a. give up
b. get across
c. throw away
d. bring up
5. I don't want to _____ learning English! It's difficult, but I can do it!
a. give up
b. calm down
c. put away
d. put off
6. My essay was thorough because I didn't want to _____ any supporting points.
a. fill in
b. leave out
c. figure out
d. turn off
7. Aaron will be late to the meeting because he had to _____ his application at the front office.
a. call off
b. get across
c. give back
d. drop off
8. Muhamad didn't want to _____ his wife, so he rushed home after school.
a. build up
b. break down
c. let down
d. calm down
8. The CEO has a great vision for the company, but can she _____ all that she intends?

a. carry out
b. hang up
c. leave out
d. give out

9. I didn't realize I'd have to _____ the money that I received for financial aid.

a. call back
b. give out
c. give back
d. fill up

1.3.4.1.3. Exercise 5-Meaning Practice

Match the phrasal verb to its meaning.

a. learn new information	b. return	c. exclude	d. leave
e. bring attention to	f. remove	g. solve	h. postpone
i. help someone understand	j. cancel	k. implement	l. disappoint
m. explain thoroughly			

1. _____ drop off
2. _____ find out
3. _____ figure out
4. _____ get across
5. _____ give back
6. _____ let down
7. _____ take off
8. _____ leave out
9. _____ call off
10. _____ put off
11. _____ break down
12. _____ carry out
13. _____ bring up

1.3.4.2. Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

Inseparable phrasal verbs must be kept together. Transitive phrasal verbs (verbs that can have an object) can be followed by a noun or pronoun. Look at the examples.

1. The teacher is trying to **keep up with** grading the homework.
2. The teacher is trying to **keep up with** it.

It is a challenge determining whether a phrasal verb is separable or inseparable, but one strategy to help you is to remember that most three-word phrasal verbs cannot be separated.

Phrasal Verb	**Meaning**	**Phrasal Verb**	**Meaning**
carry on	continue	cash in on	profit from
fall for	believe a trick	follow through with	complete
get off	leave	get on	board
get out of	leave	get over	recover
get through with	finish/endure	get to	access/upset
get together with	meet	go over	review
keep up with	maintain pace	look after	care for
look back on	remember	pick on	bully
put up with	tolerate	see about	consider
stand for	represent	take after	resemble
talk over	discuss	touch on	briefly mention
turn into	become	watch out for	be careful of

Table 12 Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

1.3.4.2.1. Exercise 6-Meaning Practice

Match the phrasal verb to its meaning.

a. tolerate	b. review	c. continue	d. recover	e. remember
f. resemble	g. become	h. complete	i. discuss	j. consider
k. represent	l. leave	m. care for	n. bully	o. maintain pace

1. _____ carry on
2. _____ take after
3. _____ stand for
4. _____ put up with
5. _____ get out of
6. _____ go over
7. _____ turn into
8. _____ follow through with
9. _____ get over
10. _____ keep up with = maintain pace
11. _____ look back on
12. _____ talk over
13. _____ look after = care for
14. _____ pick on = bully
15. _____ see about

1.3.4.2.2. Exercise 7-Pronoun Objects

Read the sentences that have a noun used with a phrasal verb. Rewrite the sentence using a pronoun. Use the example as a guide.

Example: Sadie always **falls for** her brother's tricks. = Sadie always **falls for** them.

1. The governor will follow through with his plans.
2. Rebecca couldn't wait to get over her symptoms and begin feeling better.
3. The teacher will not put up with disrespectful students.
4. I did my best to keep up with my homework.
5. Watch out for potholes while driving on that road.

1.3.4.2.3. Exercise 8-Inseparable Phrasal Verbs Meaning Practice in Context

Read the sentences and determine which phrasal verb would be the most appropriate considering its meaning.

1. The professor's lecture _____ the differences between the Christian denominations.

a. carried on
b. stood for
c. touched on
d. fell for

2. Penelope _____ her little sister.

a. takes after
b. looks after
c. goes over
d. follow through with

3. Daren _____ his dad's personality.

a. takes after
b. looks back on
c. cashes in on
d. sees about

4. Let's _____ the grammar rules one more time.

a. get over
b. carry on
c. put up with
d. go over

5. The letters used in algebra _____ numbers.

a. carry on
b. stand for
c. get on

d. watch out for

6. Before a plant _____ fruit, it must be pollenated.

a. turns into

b. takes after

c. stands for

d. looks after

7. He needs more time to _____ his writing assignments.

a. look back on

b. fall for

c. turn into

d. keep up with

8. Sometimes the person that _____ others has personal problems.

a. picks on

b. look back on

c. get out of

d. follow through with

9. The passenger wanted to _____ the bus, so he rang the bell.

a. get together with

b. put up with

c. stand for

d. get off

10. Instead of punishing a child for doing something wrong, _____ the consequences.

a. see about

b. talk over

c. look after

d. watch out for

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1.3.4.3. Phrasal Verbs with Multiple Meanings

Sometimes phrasal verbs can have multiple meanings. The same two or three words can be separable for one meaning and inseparable for another meaning. They might be transitive with one meaning and intransitive for another meaning. Look at the table for common phrasal verbs with multiple meanings and their example sentences.

Phrasal Verb	Meanings	Examples						
break down	a. stop working	b. end in failure	c. have an emotional crisis	d. analyze something complex	a. My car broke down.	b. Negotiations broke down, so they changed their strategy.	c. She broke down when she heard the bad news.	d. The teacher broke down the math problem.
bring up	a. raise	b. mention	a. She brought up three beautiful children.	b. Why did he bring up that sensitive topic?				
back up	a. make a copy	b. support or prove	c. cause an accumulation of something like cars	d. move backwards	a. I backed up my pictures from my phone online.	b. She backed up her claim with evidence.	c. The accident caused cars to back up the freeway.	d. The car hit the trash cans while backing up.

blow up	a. explode	b. fill something with air	c. enlarge a picture or document	d. suddenly display anger	e. overwhelm something like a phone or email	a. The bomb blew up.	b. Henry blew up the balloons.	c. I blew up the picture because the original was small.	d. He blew up when he saw the thieves broke his window.	e. My phone blew up with messages when my name appeared on the news.
check out	a. leave a hotel or building	b. pay for items	c. borrow from a library	d. examine or try something	e. verify facts as valid	a. He checked out of the hotel.	b. He checked out the groceries at self-checkout.	c. He checked out a calculator at the library.	d. He checked out the new restaurant his friends talked about.	e. His story checked out. He was at home when he said he was.
cut off	a. remove something	b. stop the supply of something	c. interrupt someone	d. cause disconnection of a phone or internet	a. I cut off the tag because it bothered my neck.	b. I cut off the water when he started spraying me.	c. I cut him off when he started lying.	d. Her phone cut off, so I couldn't finish the conversation.		
go out	a. leave your home	b. stop burning	a. He went out with his friends last Friday.	b. The fire went out after an hour.						
look up	a. search	b. improve	c. admire	a. I looked up the word in the dictionary.	b. Things are looking up after the holidays.	c. He looks up to his father.				
make out	a. be able to identify or see with great effort	b. write details on a check	c. kiss in a sexual way	a. I couldn't make out who was in the picture because it was too small.	b. Please make out the check to me.	c. Students cannot make out on school property.				
make up	a. invent	b. compose	c. no longer be upset	d. compensate for a lack of something	a. Children make up stories.	b. Flour, butter, and egg make up the dough.	c. We made up after talking about the problem.	d. The teacher allowed the student to make up the missing homework.		
pick up	a. lift something	b. give someone a ride	c. learn a new skill	d. buy something at the store	e. notice something; detect	f. start again	g. improve	a. I couldn't pick up the chair. It's heavy.	b. I picked up the children from school.	c. I picked up Albanian while living in Tetovo.	d. I picked up milk and bread.	e. Children pick up when their parents are angry.
take off	a. remove	b. leave the ground	c. become successful	d. take time from work	e. leave a place	a. He took off his jacket.	b. The plane took off after an hour delay.	c. Her career took off after her internship.	d. I took off three days to study for a test.	e. He took off from the party around 3am.		

turn down	a. reduce intensity	b. reject an offer or request	a. I turned down the volume of the radio.	b. I turned down his offer to have dinner.
work out	a. exercise	b. solve a problem	a. He works out three days a week.	b. They worked out their differences.

Table 13 Phrasal Verbs with Multiple Meanings

1.3.4.3.1. Exercise 9-Which meaning?

Read the sentences that have phrasal verbs with multiple meanings. Choose the appropriate meaning using the context of the sentence.

1. Billy works out at a gym, but I prefer to work out at home.

a. exercise

b. solve a problem

2. I didn't teach Hadi Arabic. He picked it up while listening to his cousins.

a. lift something

b. give someone a ride

c. learn a new skill

d. buy something at the store

e. notice something; detect

f. start again

g. improve

3. The job opportunity was just too good to turn down!

a. reduce intensity

b. reject an offer or request

4. Owen made up a story so that he didn't get in trouble.

a. invent

b. compose

c. no longer be upset

d. compensate for a lack of something

5. The economy is starting to pick up now that people are getting vaccinated.

a. lift something

b. give someone a ride

c. learn a new skill

d. buy something at the store

e. notice something; detect

f. start again

g. improve

6. The painting in the cave was so old, the archeologists couldn't make out the script.

a. be able to identify or see with great effort

b. write details on a check

c. kiss in a sexual way

7. After she transferred to Reedley College, things were looking up. She was learning a lot, making new friends, and having a good time with family.

a. search

b. improve

c. admire

8. Before working on the pipe, please cut off the water.

a. remove something

*b. stop the supply of something

c. interrupt someone

d. cause disconnection of a phone or internet

9. If he mentions politics or religion, please cut him off. These topics are not relevant to our discussion.

a. remove something

b. stop the supply of something

c. interrupt someone

d. cause disconnection of a phone or internet

10. I hope your passion never goes out.

a. leave your home
b. stop burning

11. The employer wanted to know more about the applicant, so he looked her up on social media.
a. search
b. improve
c. admire

12. I checked out the new coffee shop by the college. It's superb!
a. leave a hotel or building
b. pay for items
c. borrow from a library
d. examine or try something
e. verify facts as valid

13. The boss blew up when he didn't hear the answer he wanted from his employee.
a. explode
b. fill something with air
c. enlarge a picture or document
d. suddenly display anger
e. overwhelm something like a phone or email

14. Age should never be brought up in an interview. That information is irrelevant.
a. raise
b. mention

15. Their communication broke down, so they needed help.
a. stop working
b. end in failure
c. have an emotional crisis
d. analyze something complex

16. I emailed my essay, but I also backed it up on my USB just in case.
a. make a copy
b. support or prove
c. cause an accumulation of something like cars
d. move backwards

17. Twitter blew up when the news broke that he committed fraud.
a. explode
b. fill something with air
c. enlarge a picture or document
d. suddenly display anger
e. overwhelm something like a phone or email

18. He backed up his points on the essay with information from experts.
a. make a copy
b. support or prove
c. cause an accumulation of something like cars
d. move backwards

19. Can we ever make up for sleep that we've lost?
a. invent
b. compose
c. no longer be upset
d. compensate for a lack of something

20. Animals can pick up smells that humans cannot.
a. lift something
b. give someone a ride
c. learn a new skill
d. buy something at the store
e. notice something; detect
f. start again
g. improve

Links on the original page

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- An Introduction to Phrasal Verbs: https://youtu.be/e7tZSwasnRo

3.5: Applying Grammar to Reading

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

1.3.5.1. Exercise 10-Examples from the Chapter's Reading

Match the examples from this chapter's reading to the meaning of the phrasal verbs.

a. discover	b. handle	c. quit	d. consist of
e. invent	f. eventually in a situation you did not plan	g. experiment with; test	

_____ 1. We've all felt confused before, and it can be one of the most frustrating feelings to **deal with** (Paragraph 1).

_____ 2. At other times, people make educated guesses or **make up** an answer even if they know it isn't right (Paragraph 2).

_____ 3. Fighting confusion **ends up** making us more confused (Paragraph 4).

_____ 4. Identity is also **made up of** your values and goals (Paragraph 5).

_____ 5. People **figure out** their identity in two steps (Paragraph 5).

_____ 6. The first step is exploration, where you **try out** different groups and values and see what fits (Paragraph 5).

_____ 7. Before you **give up**, make sure you have someone to help you and the resources you need to resolve your confusion (Paragraph 5).

3.6: Communication Practice

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

1.3.6.1. Exercise 11-Chain Stories

The sentence below is the beginning of a story. Each member of your group should add two sentences to the story using at least one phrasal verb. The story can be shocking, funny, wonderful, or embarrassing, but it is a story that should make sense. Be creative!

First sentence of the story: Yesterday began like any other day.

Phrasal Verbs

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

5.3.1. Separable Phrasal Verbs

Phrasal Verb	**Meaning**	**Phrasal Verb**	**Meaning**
ask over*	invite	blow up	explode
bring back	return	bring up	bring attention to
build up	increase	break down	thoroughly explain
call back*	return a phone call	call off	cancel
carry out	implement	calm down	decrease emotions
drop off	leave someone or something at a place	figure out	understand or solve
fill in	complete	fill out	complete
fill up	fill completely	fix up	repair/make presentable
find out	learn new information	get across	get people to understand
give up	quit	give out	distribute
give back	return	hang up	end a phone call
help out	assist	leave out	exclude
let down	disappoint	pass down	give
pick up	lift/get	put away	put in the correct place
put off	postpone	take off	remove
throw away	put in the trash	turn on/off	make something open or start/ stop or finish

Table 30 Separable Phrasal Verbs

5.3.2. Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

Phrasal Verb	**Meaning**	**Phrasal Verb**	**Meaning**
carry on	continue	cash in on	profit from
fall for	believe a trick	follow through with	complete
get off	leave	get on	board
get out of	leave	get over	recover
get through with	finish/endure	get to	access/upset
get together with	meet	go over	review
keep up with	maintain pace	look after	care for
look back on	remember	pick on	bully
put up with	tolerate	see about	consider
stand for	represent	take after	resemble
talk over	discuss	touch on	briefly mention
turn into	become	watch out for	be careful of

Table 31 Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

5.3.3. Phrasal Verbs with Multiple Meanings

Phrasal Verb	**Meanings**	**Examples**

break down	a. stop working	b. end in failure	c. have an emotional crisis	d. analyze something complex	a. My car broke down.	b. Negotiations broke down, so they changed their strategy.	c. She broke down when she heard the bad news.	d. The teacher broke down the math problem.		
bring up	a. raise	b. mention	a. She brought up three beautiful children.	b. Why did he bring up that sensitive topic?						
back up	a. make a copy	b. support or prove	c. cause an accumulation of something like cars	d. move backwards	a. I backed up my pictures from my phone online.	b. She backed up her claim with evidence.	c. The accident caused cars to back up the freeway.	d. The car hit the trash cans while backing up.		
blow up	a. explode	b. fill something with air	c. enlarge a picture or document	d. suddenly display anger	e. overwhelm something like a phone or email	a. The bomb blew up.	b. Henry blew up the balloons.	c. I blew up the picture because the original was small.	d. He blew up when he saw the thieves broke his window.	e. My phone blew up with messages when my name appeared on the news.
check out	a. leave a hotel or building	b. pay for items	c. borrow from a library	d. examine or try something	e. verify facts as valid	a. He checked out of the hotel.	b. He checked out the groceries at self-checkout.	c. He checked out a calculator at the library.	d. He checked out the new restaurant his friends talked about.	e. His story checked out. He was at home when he said he was.
cut off	a. remove something	b. stop the supply of something	c. interrupt someone	d. cause disconnection of a phone or internet	a. I cut off the tag because it bothered my neck.	b. I cut off the water when he started spraying me.	c. I cut him off when he started lying.	d. Her phone cut off, so I couldn't finish the conversation.		
go out	a. leave your home	b. stop burning	a. He went out with his friends last Friday.	b. The fire went out after an hour.						
look up	a. search	b. improve	c. admire	a. I looked up the word in the dictionary.	b. Things are looking up after the holidays.	c. He looks up to his father.				
make out	a. be able to identify or see with great effort	b. write details on a check	c. kiss in a sexual way	a. I couldn't make out who was in the picture because it was too small.	b. Please make out the check to me.	c. Students cannot make out on school property.				

make up	a. invent	b. compose	c. no longer be upset	d. compensate for a lack of something	a. Children make up stories.	b. Flour, butter, and egg make up the dough.	c. We made up after talking about the problem.	d. The teacher allowed the student to make up the missing homework.				
pick up	a. lift something	b. give someone a ride	c. learn a new skill	d. buy something at the store	e. notice something; detect	f. start again	g. improve	a. I couldn't pick up the chair. It's heavy.	b. I picked up the children from school.	c. I picked up Albanian while living in Tetovo.	d. I picked up milk and bread.	e. Children pick up when their parents are angry.
take off	a. remove	b. leave the ground	c. become successful	d. take time from work	e. leave a place	a. He took off his jacket.	b. The plane took off after an hour delay.	c. Her career took off after her internship.	d. I took off three days to study for a test.	e. He took off from the party around 3am.		
turn down	a. reduce intensity	b. reject an offer or request	a. I turned down the volume of the radio.	b. I turned down his offer to have dinner.								
work out	a. exercise	b. solve a problem	a. He works out three days a week.	b. They worked out their differences.								

Table 32 Phrasal Verbs with Multiple Meanings